on the day I began my personal yatra on this planet—7 November. I can safely say that it was the most meaningful birthday I had ever had. A torch procession marked the beginning of the Maharashtra leg of the Yatra, paving the way for powerful headlines (and hence lots of work for me as well). The Maharashtra leg also included the biggest rally that Shegaon had witnessed in decades (which was again a lot of work for me). But the most difficult and emotionally taxing part of my job in Maharashtra was the deaths of two dedicated yatris—the first passed away while marching on the very first morning in the state, and the second died in an accident near the campsite. The mood of the Yatra changed immediately and cast a pall on everyone in the Yatra. There were some unscrupulous attempts by people outside, who tried to milk these two dreadful episodes for political mileage. All the yatris were downcast and upset, for we had formed strong friendships. So we were infuriated at how low people could stoop.

The Maharashtra leg was also trying in other ways. In one instance, the regional media threw tantrums and personally attacked me on the Bharat Jodo Yatra WhatsApp circulation group for Maharashtra. The controversy was that one odd former journalist from the local newspaper *Loksatta* had managed to slip through the security of the main cavalcade to march alongside Rahul Gandhi, naturally sparking an outburst among his peers, who felt he was getting preferential treatment. Even though it wasn't my fault, in the interest of the party, I spent an entire evening repeatedly apologizing for the inadvertent breach to individual media personnel. That incident had just faded into the background when yet another entitled journalist managed to slip into the main lunch area, where all Congress leaders and yatris were resting during the afternoon break. Once again, the media fraternity was livid at the preferential treatment he got. This time around, I was even less to blame, given the media person's walk-through was actively facilitated by someone from within the Congress party's state unit. Yet, once again, I went out of my way to pacify everyone in the media. A testament to the warm culture within the Congress, my top boss in the media department, Jairam Ramesh, volunteered a sincere apology the next day at his press conference. That worked like a talisman and the situation